

Edible ink cartridges

Kopykake, a company based in California makes edible ink cartridges to be used as frostings on cakes

Nano printing

University of Illinois scientists have developed a cell copier machine that prints nanoscale biological cells

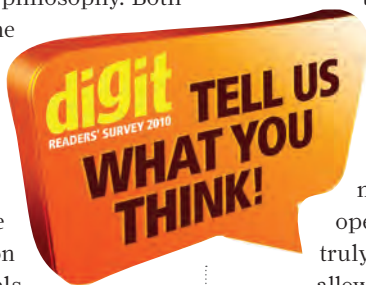
MFD test

it has an added telephone and fax functionality. The MP276 has a very basic design as far as the onboard operational panel is concerned. It has a single monochrome LED display which just shows numbers. With a button on the side to add to the number counter, you can't perform any function on the printer itself.

Canon's MP496 and MP648 both have a lovely colour LCD screen along with buttons on the operational panel. While the MP496 has a 1.8 inch LCD screen on the flap which opens on the right side of the printer, the MP648 has a larger 3-inch colour LCD screen on a flap screen that opens in the middle atop the MFD. Using these screens, you can control a lot of functions, such as paper and image quality, number of copies, scanning to USB or PC, etc., easily. During a print, scan or copy operation, you get live status on the LCD screen. The MP276 and MX328 also had PictBridge support, which allows you to take photo prints directly from a digital camera, without needing a PC.

Epson's Stylus Office series of printers were next in line and probably the most attractive MFDs that we tested. The Epson Stylus series is known for its compartmentalised aesthetics and both the TX510FN and the TX600FW lived upto

that design philosophy. Both of them came in black, sturdy bodies. The operational panel is quite impressive on both models, making navigation through the functions and menus easier. The TX600FW has a large 2.5-inch colour LCD screen, whereas the TX510FN has a more economical 2 line LCD display. Both these MFDs have a fax option along with printing, scanning and copying. The operational panel on



the TX600FW is particularly impressive as it is flexible. With the help of a spring mechanism, the operating panel is truly adjustable. This allows you to place the MFD as you like, and adjust the panel for optimal viewing.

Unlike the Canon Pixma models that we tested, the Epson models had an Automatic Document Feeder (ADF hereon) which can be used for faster scanning as compared to the flatbed scanner. The ADF section above the flatbed scanner has a wavy appearance which is quite impressive.



Epson Stylus Office TX600FW

The Canon Pixma MP648 and the Epson TX600FW were the only two MFDs in the test to feature Wi-Fi. However, setting up the Wi-Fi connection on both these printers can be annoying and tedious.

At just 150 cm in height, the Brother DCP 195C was the most compact MFD in the test. Despite the fact that it has very limited vertical area to play with, this MFD packs in a full size flatbed scanner. A very interesting feature of this MFD is the location of the USB interface. It is located within the MFD, in such a way that the USB cable is guided out through a plastic groove specially made for it. Other than that it has basic functionalities on its operational panel. Presence of the PictBridge port and memory card slot make this MFD very versatile.

Performance

Since inkjet printers are targeted at home users, we laid more stress on the photo quality print. The colour output was checked in the printing tests and in the copying tests; we compared the output to the original source to see any change in the colour gradation.

Text quality was the best in the Canon Pixma MP276, but this quality comes at the cost of time - it took a whopping 27

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